

DESIGN CODE NS 03

Axel the Axolotl

US crochet terms · Advanced beginner · 2.5–3 hours



Novality Store

A soft pink axolotl with six fluffy gills, a round head and a shell-edged paddle tail. Head, neck, body and tail are worked as one continuous spiral, so there is no neck seam to sew.

Axel measures about **11.5 cm (4.5 in)** tall seated, about **10 cm (4 in)** wide gill tip to gill tip, with a **4.3 cm (1.7 in)** tail. The head is a true sphere at **52 mm wide × 51.6 mm tall**.

Safety — read this first

Axel has **two 6 mm safety eyes**. Safety eyes are small parts. Lock the washers firmly from the inside before stuffing, and pull-test every eye on the finished toy — a properly locked washer will not come off by hand.

The gills, arms, feet and tail fin are all **sewn on**. Sew each seam twice and weave every end in for at least 5 cm, then trim close. A loose gill is the first thing a child will pull.

This pattern has not been tested to a toy-safety standard such as ASTM F963 or EN 71, so please do not describe finished Axels as "baby-safe" or "suitable from birth" in your listings. For children under 3, embroidered eyes are the safer choice: skip the safety eyes and stitch the eyes with black floss instead.

Materials

Main yarn — Worsted #4, pale pink, about **15 g**. Cotton or acrylic, smooth matte finish. One 25 g ball covers the whole axolotl with plenty to spare.

Gill yarn — Fuzzy / eyelash / fur yarn, dark pink, about **8 g**. Essential: worsted will not give fluffy gills, and the gills are the whole look.

Fin yarn — Worsted #4, dark pink, about **3 g**. Smooth yarn, so the shell edging stays crisp.

Hook — 3.5 mm (US E-4). Tight gauge so stuffing cannot show through.

Eyes — 2 × 6 mm safety eyes. 9 mm reads as buggy on this head.

Also needed — Polyfill about **8 g**; tapestry needle; black embroidery floss; pink pastel or chalk; stitch marker.

Gauge & finished size

Gauge — 36 sc around measures about **52 mm** in diameter when stuffed (4.5 mm per stitch, 4.3 mm per round).

Check it before you start: crochet 36 sc in the round for 3 rounds, stuff it, and measure across. If it comes out wider than 55 mm, drop to a 3.0 mm hook; if it comes out under 48 mm, go up to a 4.0 mm.

Finished size — About 11.5 cm (4.5 in) tall seated, about 10 cm (4 in) wide gill tip to gill tip, with a 4.3 cm (1.7 in) tail.

Abbreviations

MR magic ring · **ch** chain · **sc** single crochet · **dc** double crochet · **inc** increase, 2 sc in one stitch · **invdec** invisible decrease · **sl st** slip stitch · **st(s)** stitch(es) · **FO** fasten off · **(n)** stitch count at the end of the round

Core techniques

These are the five techniques Axel uses, in the order you will meet them.

1 • The magic ring. Every piece begins with a magic ring. Wrap the yarn once around two fingers, insert the hook, pull up a loop and work your first round into the ring, then pull the tail to close it. Pull the tail tight once the first round is complete.

2 • Work in a spiral. Do not join and do not ch 1 between rounds — just keep going round after round. Keep a stitch marker in the first stitch of every round and move it up each time; there is no join to count from.

3 • The invisible decrease. Insert the hook through the **front loops only** of the next two stitches, yarn over and pull through both, then yarn over and pull through the remaining two loops. This leaves no ridge, which matters on the head and neck where the decreases are visible.

4 • Closing through both layers. To close a flat opening, fold the piece flat so the front and back layers lie together, then work one sc through both layers at a time. Axel's 6-stitch tail tip closes as 3 clean pairs.

5 • The shell (scallop). Work all the stitches of the group into **one** stitch, then slip stitch into the next stitch to anchor it. The group fans out into a cup. Working the dc loosely makes each scallop cup outward instead of lying flat.

1. Head, neck, body & tail — one piece

Worked in a single spiral from the top of the head straight through to the tail tip. Head and body are both 36 stitches around; the neck at R13 is the only waist. Three straight rounds at the head keep it spherical rather than egg-shaped.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	start at top of head
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	
R3	[1 sc, inc] ×6	(18)	
R4	[2 sc, inc] ×6	(24)	
R5	[3 sc, inc] ×6	(30)	
R6	[4 sc, inc] ×6	(36)	head at full width
R7	sc in each st around	(36)	eyes between R7/R8

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
R8	sc in each st around	(36)	
R9	sc in each st around	(36)	smile on R8–R9
R10	[4 sc, invdec] ×6	(30)	
R11	[3 sc, invdec] ×6	(24)	STUFF HEAD FIRMLY
R12	[2 sc, invdec] ×6	(18)	
R13	sc in each st around	(18)	NECK — narrowest point
R14	[2 sc, inc] ×6	(24)	body flares out
R15	[3 sc, inc] ×6	(30)	
R16	[4 sc, inc] ×6	(36)	body at full width
R17	sc in each st around	(36)	arms attach at R17–R18
R18	sc in each st around	(36)	
R19	sc in each st around	(36)	
R20	sc in each st around	(36)	
R21	sc in each st around	(36)	
R22	sc in each st around	(36)	
R23	[4 sc, invdec] ×6	(30)	
R24	[3 sc, invdec] ×6	(24)	FEET at R24–R25
R25	[2 sc, invdec] ×6	(18)	stuff body LIGHTLY
R26	[1 sc, invdec] ×6	(12)	
R27	sc in each st around	(12)	tail begins
R28	[2 sc, invdec] ×3	(9)	
R29	sc in each st around	(9)	
R30	sc in each st around	(9)	
R31	sc in each st around	(9)	
R32	[1 sc, invdec] ×3	(6)	light stuffing to here
R33	sc in each st around	(6)	
R34	sc in each st around	(6)	
R35	sc in each st around	(6)	
R36	sc in each st around	(6)	taper to tip

Finish. Flatten the tip and work 3 sc through both layers — 6 stitches closes as 3 clean pairs. FO.

Weave the final yarn end back through the tail tip and out along the top ridge — you will crochet the fin directly onto that ridge in step 4. The tail runs R27–R36, ten rounds ≈ 43 mm, which is what gives the fin a long enough ridge to sit on.

2. Arms & feet — make separately, then sew

The arms and feet are sewn on, not worked into the body — bobbles will not give you rounded limbs.

Arm — make 2 (pale pink)

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)
R2	sc in each st around	(6)
R3	sc in each st around	(6)
R4	sc in each st around	(6)
R5	sc in each st around	(6)
R6	sc in each st around	(6)

Finish. FO, long tail, do not stuff.

Foot — make 2 (pale pink)

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)
R2	[1 sc, inc] ×3	(9)
R3	sc in each st around	(9)
R4	sc in each st around	(9)
R5	[1 sc, invdec] ×3	(6)

Finish. FO, cinch closed, long tail.

Arms stay unstuffed so they hang softly; flatten the open end and sew it closed as you attach. Feet are lightly stuffed and cinched round — do not flatten them, they are plump little balls.

3. Gills — make 6 (3 per side)

Use the fuzzy yarn here. This is the single biggest visual difference between a flat-looking axolotl and a real one.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)
R2	inc in each st around	(12)
R3	sc in each st around	(12)

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
R4	sc in each st around	(12)
R5	[1 sc, invdec] ×4	(8)

Finish. FO, long tail for sewing.

Working with fuzzy yarn. You cannot see the stitches. Two things make it easy: hold a thin strand of matching smooth yarn together with the fur yarn so you can find the stitches, or count by feel with the hook tip and trust the round count. Small errors are invisible in the finished fluff.

4. Tail fin — shell edging

With smooth dark pink yarn, join with a sl st to the top ridge of the tail at the very tip. Working along the ridge back towards the body:

***5 dc in the next ridge stitch, sl st in the next ridge stitch. Repeat from * a total of 5 times (5 scallops).**
FO and weave in.

Each scallop uses 2 ridge stitches, so the fin spans 10 stitches. The tail from R27 to R36 gives a ridge of about 10 workable stitches along one side, so 5 scallops fit it exactly — start at the tip and work back toward the body. Work the dc groups loosely so each scallop cups outward instead of lying flat.

For a fuller paddle, work a second identical 5-scallop row along the underside ridge rather than trying to stretch one row around the tip.

5. Face & assembly

Eyes. Insert the 6 mm safety eyes between R7 and R8, 6 stitches apart, centered on the front of the head. Six stitches spans about 27 mm on the 52 mm head — exactly half the width. Fix the washers before stuffing, and pull-test each eye once it is locked.

Smile. With black floss, embroider a wide shallow U across R8–R9, centered between the eyes and about 5 stitches wide. Keep it shallow; a deep curve reads as a frown.

Blush. Brush soft pink pastel or chalk in a small circle directly under each eye, just outside the eye line.

Gills. Sew 3 lobes to each side of the head, behind the eyes, anchored at about R6 (upper), R7–R8 (middle) and R9 (lower). Angle the top lobe upward, the middle one straight out and the bottom one downward so they fan. Then tease the fibers apart with a slicker brush or your fingers.

Arms. Sew one arm to each side at R17–R18, about 6 stitches out from the center front, angled slightly forward.

Feet. Sew one foot to each side of the center front at R24–R25, about 4 stitches out from center, so Axel sits flat and upright.

Troubleshooting

Head firm, body soft. Stuff the head hard at R11 so it holds a sphere and the eyes stay level. Keep the body light so Axel stays squishy and sits down.

Neck collapsing. The 18-stitch neck is deliberately narrow. First try packing a little more stuffing into the neck through the body opening before you close R25. For a permanently sturdier neck, work R13 as [7 sc, inc] ×2, 2 sc (20) — and then change R14 to [4 sc, inc] ×4 (24) so the round consumes all 20 stitches. R15 onward is unchanged.

Fin runs out of tail. The ridge holds 10 stitches and 5 scallops need exactly 10. If you shortened the tail, work fewer scallops rather than crowding them.

Want a wider gill span? The gills as written give about 10 cm tip to tip. Work each gill two rounds longer — add 2 plain rounds at 12 stitches before R5 — for a span of about 12 cm.

Stuffing shows through. Go down to a 3.0 mm hook. Loose gauge on a 3.5 mm hook is the usual cause.

Axel will not sit. Move the feet one round lower and make sure the R23–R26 decreases are centered on the underside, not the back.

Colorways

Classic pink; white leucistic (white body, pale pink gills); melanoid black (charcoal body, grey gills); mint; and lavender.

The finished project

Axel seated, gills teased out and the shell fin along the tail.

Lay every component out and check it against the pattern before you sew anything: 1 body, 2 arms, 2 feet, 6 gills, 1 fin.

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